

1 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 30 minutes

Invent a five-minute board game

What we are practising

Turn an idea into explicit rules and revise after observing play.

What you need

Paper / Pencil / Two large paper counters

Use crossed-out marks instead of movable counters.

Before you begin

Draw a track of twelve spaces with a start and finish.

Use large counters, avoid gambling or real prizes, and let players stop freely.

Try it together

1. Choose a turn rule, such as move one or two spaces, and an exact winning condition.
2. Add one optional decision, such as a shortcut that costs the next turn.
3. Play a short round with a partner and note questions about the rules.
4. Revise one rule, then play again and compare.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Could a player get stuck forever or be unable to make a legal move?

Space to explore

2 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 30 minutes

A comic without words

What we are practising

Communicate a sequence without relying on dialogue or captions.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Arrange four quick sketches instead of polished drawings.

Before you begin

Divide a sheet into four panels and choose a harmless problem, such as a rolling pencil.

Keep the story fictional and avoid sharing identifying drawings of real children.

Try it together

1. Show the setting and object in panel one.
2. Show a cause and a consequence in panels two and three.
3. Resolve or develop the situation in panel four.
4. Ask a reader to retell the story and revise an unclear visual clue.

Talk, draw or show your idea

What does the reader need to see to understand why the next event happens?

Space to explore

3 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 30 minutes

One-sheet standing sculpture

What we are practising

Explore how shape and base size affect a simple design.

What you need

One sheet of paper / Pencil / Ruler if available

Use two equal half-sheets for two smaller designs.

Before you begin

Choose a clear flat table and set the constraint: no tape, glue or cutting.

Keep models on a low table and avoid standing on furniture to measure or display them.

Try it together

1. Sketch two ways folds might make the sheet stand.
2. Build one version and check whether it stands for ten seconds.
3. Change a fold or widen the base, then test again.
4. Record the design's height and describe the most useful change.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Can a taller sculpture also be stable, and what tradeoff appears?

Space to explore

4 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 30 minutes

A sign everyone can read

What we are practising

Use visual hierarchy, contrast and testing to improve communication.

What you need

Paper / Dark pencil or pen

Describe the sign aloud and ask a partner to sketch it.

Before you begin

Choose a fictional sign purpose, such as quiet reading corner or return books here.

Use pretend locations; do not replace real safety signs or claim universal accessibility from one test.

Try it together

1. Draw one large symbol and a short label.
2. Make the main message stand out using size and empty space.
3. Show it to a partner without explaining and ask what it means.
4. Revise confusing details and test from a little farther away.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Would the message still work without colour?

Space to explore

5 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

A scene made of sounds

What we are practising

Select and arrange sound details to imply a setting and change.

What you need

No materials

Use written sound words or silent gestures instead.

Before you begin

Choose a setting such as a calm rainy garden, keeping the sound level comfortable.

Avoid loud or sudden sounds and offer a silent version to anyone who prefers it.

Try it together

1. List three possible sounds, such as fingertip rain, a soft bird whistle and a rustling hand motion.
2. Arrange a beginning, a change and an ending using the sounds.
3. Perform the scene for about thirty seconds without naming the setting.
4. Ask a listener what they imagined, then revise one sound or pause.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Which sound suggested the setting most clearly?

Space to explore

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

1. Invent a five-minute board game

A little hint

Decide what happens if a move would pass the finish before play begins.

Answer / what to notice

Many designs work if players can understand turns, legal moves and how the game ends.

Playtesting reveals unclear rules and unintended loops that are hard to notice in a sketch.

Make it easier

Use a straight track with only one turn rule.

Take it further

Make a cooperative version where both players work toward a shared goal.

Another day, away from the screen

Write a one-page rule sheet and let another pair try without coaching.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

2. A comic without words

A little hint

Repeating a distinctive object helps the reader track it across panels.

Answer / what to notice

A successful sequence lets a reader explain the main events without added narration; simple stick figures are enough.

Readers infer movement and time from differences between successive pictures.

Make it easier

Use three panels: before, problem and after.

Take it further

Tell the same story from a different camera viewpoint without changing events.

Another day, away from the screen

Create an alternative ending and compare how it changes the meaning.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

3. One-sheet standing sculpture

A little hint

A wider base often helps, while using more paper in the base may reduce height.

Answer / what to notice

Many folded forms work; success means standing unaided under the chosen conditions, not reaching a fixed height.

Folds change stiffness and where the paper's weight is supported; the base must support the whole form.

Make it easier

Make a simple tent fold and compare two opening widths.

Take it further

Design for both a minimum height and a maximum base width you choose in advance.

Another day, away from the screen

Draw a labelled museum card explaining the sculpture's construction.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

4. A sign everyone can read

A little hint

Pair an understandable shape with words instead of relying on colour alone.

Answer / what to notice

A useful sign communicates its intended action clearly; testing may show that the first symbol needs a better label.

A symbol is not automatically universal; readable words and user feedback reduce ambiguity.

Make it easier

Improve an adult-drawn sign by enlarging its key words.

Take it further

Make matching Arabic and English versions and adjust reading direction naturally.

Another day, away from the screen

Create a consistent set of three signs for an imaginary library.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

5. A scene made of sounds

A little hint

A gradual change from frequent taps to silence can suggest rain stopping.

Answer / what to notice

Different listeners may imagine different places; explain the intended clues and accept reasonable interpretations.

Sequence, loudness and silence can communicate change without spoken narration.

Make it easier

Use two sounds and let an adult narrate.

Take it further

Create two contrasting scenes using exactly the same three sound sources.

Another day, away from the screen

Write a sound score with symbols another person could perform.